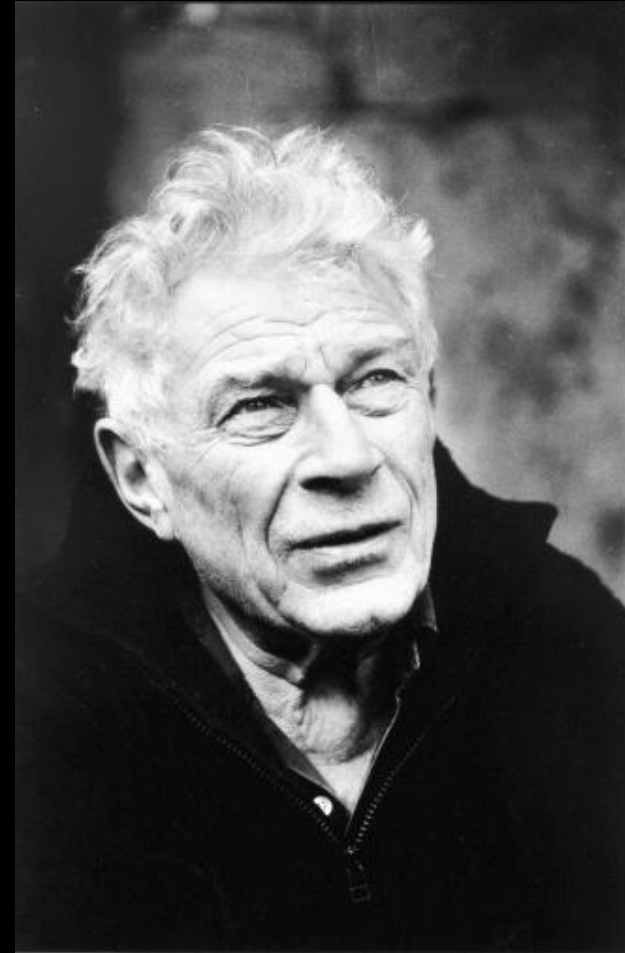


Vision, Knowledge and Power

Ways of Seeing

Seeing comes before words. The child looks and recognizes before it can speak. But, there is also another sense in which seeing comes before words. It is seeing which establishes our place in the surrounding world; we explain that world with words, but words can never undo the fact that we are surrounded by it. The relation between what we see and what we know is never settled.

John Berger, *Ways of Seeing*



I saw it with my own eyes

do you see what I mean?

it's staring you in the face

what is your point of view?

she really does have a vision

use your eyes

what is your outlook on life?

do you share my perspective?

eye, eyeing, ocular, sight, see, seeing, seen, vision, visual, visualise, visuality, scope, -scope (tele-, micro-), gaze, stare, regard, glance, glimpse, look, looks (-- like, good --), overlook, observe, observer, observation, survey, surveillance, watch, watcher, view, viewer, inspect, inspector, voyeur, spectate, spectator, spectacle, picture, depiction, representation, scene, sight(s), introspect, insight, unseeing, blind



Magritte, The Treachery of Images, 1948



voir to see
savoir to know

Some questions (which we will look at today and in class – “AIMS OF LECTURE”)

How does vision shape the world it seeks to represent/explain?

How is vision tied up with power relations?

How does vision produce/reproduce/challenge social relations of inequality and injustice?

How is vision political?

Vision, Looking, Power

- 'to gaze implies more than to look at – it signifies a ... relation of power, in which the gazer is superior to the object of the gaze' (Schroeder, 1998)
- If how we see is tied up with power then perhaps it can be linked to how we see and think of the world, and to modernity, inequality and colonization, slavery ...

Human Zoos

- In the 19th century and into the 20th century, a number of World Fairs or Expositions were held by major European Countries such as France, the UK, Belgium and Spain – as well as the US.
- As part of this, some colonial powers “imported” people from the places that they had colonised, in order to “exhibit” them.

bell hooks

- The oppositional gaze....in *Black Looks: Race and Representation* (Boston: South End Press, 1992, pp. 115-31)
- “When thinking about black female spectators, I remember being punished as a child for staring, for those hard intense direct looks children would give grown-ups, looks that were seen as confrontational, as gestures of resistance, challenges to authority. The “gaze” has always been political in my life ...Afraid to look, but fascinated by the gaze. There is power in looking.’ (hooks, 1992: 115)

bell hooks

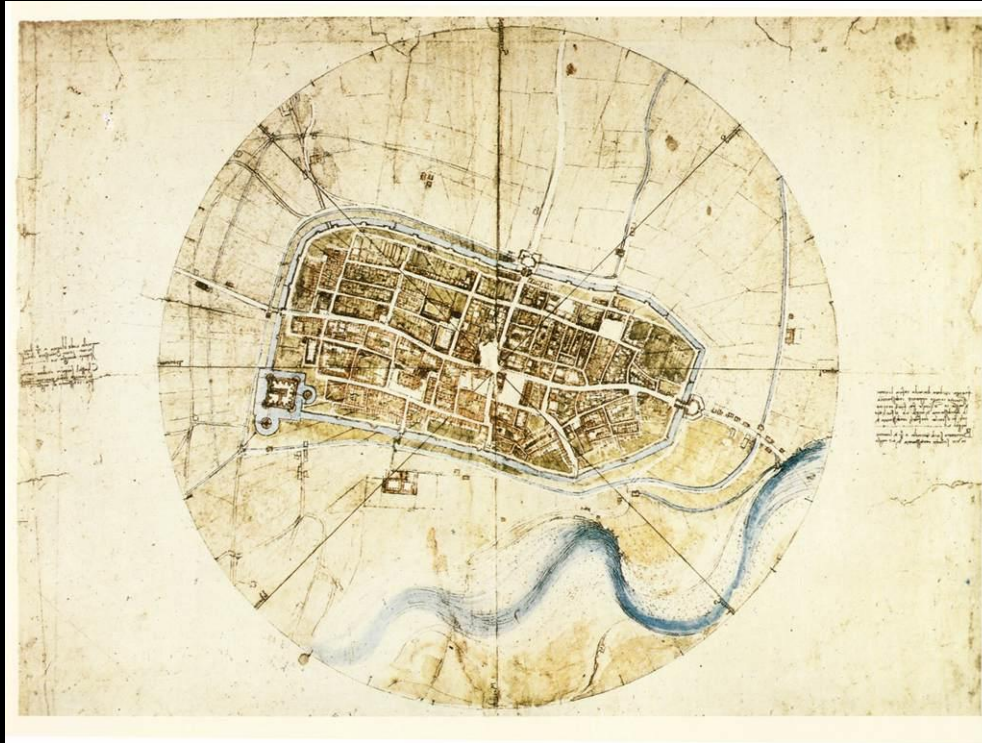
- ‘all attempts to repress our/black peoples’ right to gaze had produced in us an overwhelming longing to look, a rebellious desire, an *oppositional gaze*. By courageously looking, we defiantly declared: “Not only will I stare. I want my look to change reality.” Even in the worse circumstances of domination, the ability to manipulate one’s gaze in the face of structures of domination that would contain it, opens up the possibility of agency.’ (hooks, 1992: 116)

- ‘the first time I read in history classes that white slave-owners (men, women, and children) punished enslaved black people for looking, I wondered how this traumatic relationship to the gaze had informed ... black spectatorship’ (hooks, 1992: 115)
- ‘The politics of slavery, of racialized power relations, were such that slaves were denied their right to gaze’ (hooks, 1992: 115)

The Mercator Projection



DONNA HARAWAY ON SITUATED KNOWLEDGE



Map of Imola, Leonardo da Vinci, 1502

The bird's-eye view, in research, is a view that claims to be pure/from nowhere

There is no researcher 'in the picture'

This is 'the god-trick of seeing everything from nowhere', Haraway, 1991, *Simians, Cyborgs and Women*, p. 189.

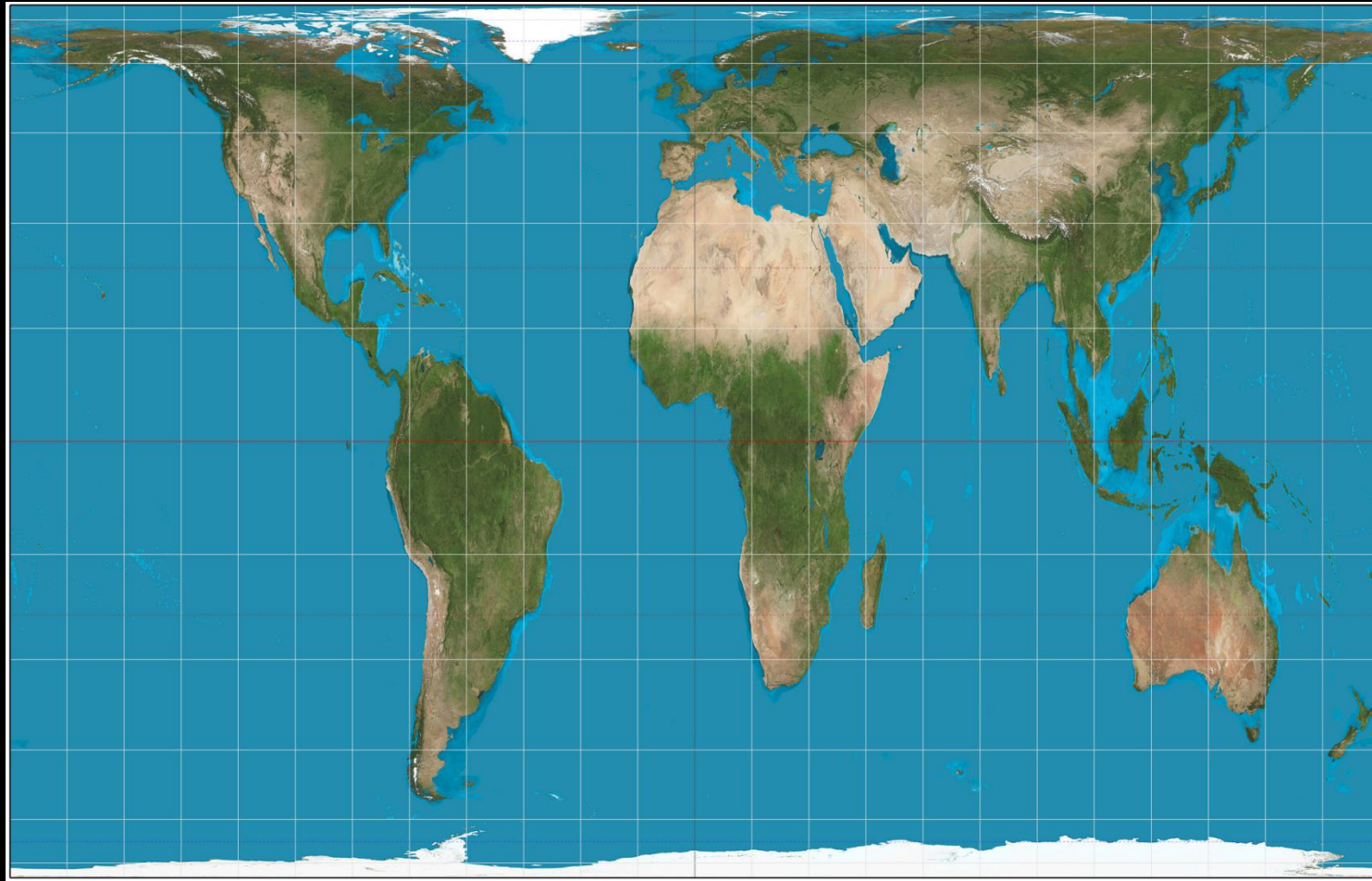
In fact it is the subjective view of the dominant (unmarked) group, passed off as universal

Knowledge that is un-locatable is also knowledge that is irresponsible

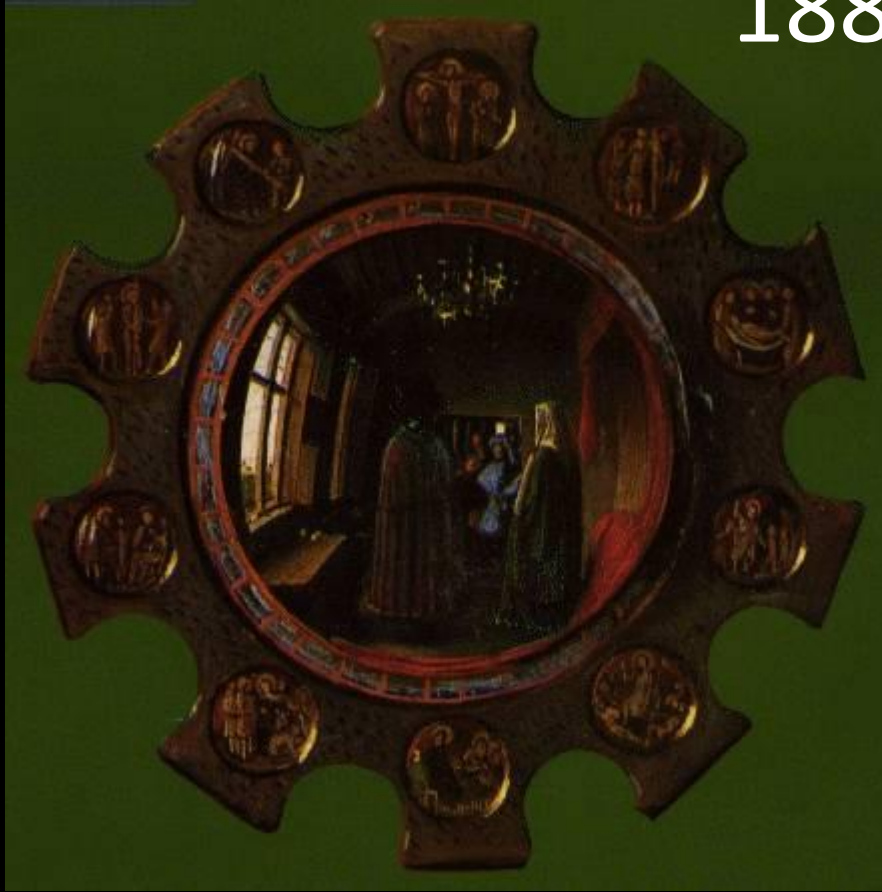
Researchers must acknowledge, and be held to account for, where their 'vision' comes from: 'we might become answerable for what we learn how to see', Haraway, 1991, *Simians, Cyborgs and Women*, p. 190.

KNOWLEDGE IS ALWAYS SITUATED

Other ways of seeing the world – (Gall-Peters Projection)



The Persistence of Vision (From Haraway, 1991: pp. 188-96)



Detail, The Arnolfini Marriage, Jan van Eyck, 1434

- All knowledge, for Haraway, is partial and situated
- Objective knowledge is the product of a particular, embodied vision
- Haraway argues that 'the standpoints of the subjugated are ... preferred because in principle they are least likely to allow denial of the critical and interpretive core of all knowledge'
- The issue for Haraway is not about men's experience (and hence knowledge) versus women's experience (and hence knowledge), but about situated knowledges versus the 'view from nowhere'
- 'The only way to find a larger vision is to be somewhere in particular.' Haraway, 1991, *Simians, Cyborgs and Women*, p.196

The World turned Upside Down



ni **NEW INTERNATIONALIST**

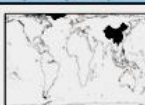
OXFORD	TORONTO	AGENCE	CHRISTIANBURGH
401 Reading Road	404 Richmond Street	28 Austin Street	P.O. Box 36559
Canby	Ontario, Canada M5T 1A5	St. Louis, MO 63101	
USA/12th	Toronto	St. Louis	Christchurch
UK	London	Australia	New Zealand
	NYC 10013	Australia	Australia

www.newint.org

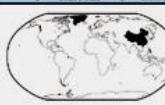
The New Internationalist magazine reports on issues of world poverty and inequality. It brings to the people the ideas and the action in the fight for global justice.



Managing Projects



Peptide Synthesis



Endocrine Protection

The Usher-Dyer Equal Area Projection

All printed world maps we see show a shape and size of the earth. This is not half of the map-makers' job stress. In representing a spherical surface on a flat map, they need only pick one shape and try to fit the principle — the grid will not be that small piece.

Cartographers have long sought some way that the globe is transferred to paper.

[illegible]

of longitude do not meet in a point at the poles. Another area projection, called the Peters Projection, uses a similar principle but shape is less consistent in lower latitudes. Commonly used projections, such as the Robinson Projection usually fail to preserve equality of area, shape, angle or distance but offer a compromise between these properties.

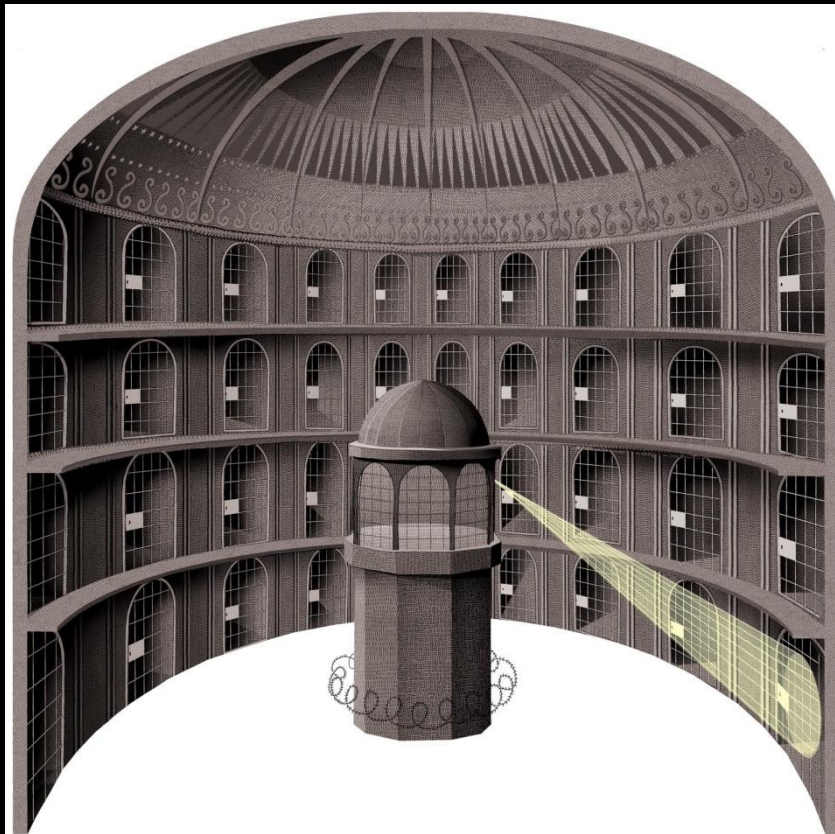
The Hahn-Dye Projection allows the display of geographic data, whether topographic or thematic, without scale bias or region. The loss of true shape (distortion of about 40 degrees) is a small price to pay for the preservation of equal area.

- But, because the knowledges, and ways of seeing, of dominant groups are seen as 'normal', because they are taken for granted as 'true', it is difficult to question them.
- This mention of "normal" brings us back to Foucault



Jeremy Bentham's Auto-Icon
South Corridor, Main Building, UCL

Back to Foucault – *Discipline and Punish*



- The Panopticon (All quotations from Module Reader)
- ‘Visibility is a trap’
- It sheds light on the masses and makes them visible as individuals
- ‘Bentham laid down the principle that power should be visible and unverifiable’
- This applies to prisoners, “the mad”, schoolchildren

Foucault:

- Disciplinary power produces a way of seeing
- A way of distributing light
- It enables us to see some kinds of subject (schoolchildren, patients, criminals)
- And to analyse them as objects
- This can be related to gender but is not reducible to gender (ie, it is about more than the male gaze)
- It is about the power relations of our society which encourage us to see in certain ways.

Foucault: Module Reader, p. 316

- It is not that this disciplinary power 'has replaced all the others; but because it has infiltrated the others, sometimes undermining them, but serving as an intermediary between them, linking them together, extending them and above all making it possible to bring the effects of power to the most minute and distant elements. It assures an infinitesimal distribution of the power relation.'

And what of “woman”?

Sarah Kember on medical scans of pregnant women:

The scanning process eliminates the mother's body from view and the doctor has unmediated access to the image of the foetus. The body of the woman exists only as a vehicle for scientific information.

Woman as a problem for
vision/knowledge
Woman as invisible

Sarah Kember, *Virtual Anxiety*



“The Male Gaze”

- A term invented by feminist film critic Laura Mulvey
- Audiences are invited (made) to view films from the point of view of a (heterosexual) male
- The camera lingers on the woman – as an object not a subject
- The camera (and the viewer) “enjoys” and “controls” the woman as object

